

## THE \$50-A-DAY BUDGET

Thoreau wrote, "Our life is frittered away by detail . . . I went to the woods because I wished to live deliberately, to front only the essential facts of life, and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when I came to die, discover that I had not lived."

Cutting down to the "essential facts of life" may be a little much. Even Thoreau got bored and returned to civilization after two years. But when you retire you need only a modest infrastructure in your life. You can certainly get by with less house. And if you're willing to try, you can almost as certainly get by with less car—or no car.

The simplifying rules from chapters 4 and 5 are:

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**Convert home equity to cash**  
**Convert other assets to cash**  
**Move**

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Additional rules from this chapter are:

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**Cut down your infrastructure**  
**Sell your vehicles**

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Follow the rules and you'll have plenty of money for what you used to think was expensive. Vicki and I live in beach houses for a couple of months each summer, spend six weeks to three months in Europe, attend special programs at Berklee College of Music and Cambridge's Healing Resource Center, and wander through Mayan ruins in Mexico. We go to ballet, symphony, theater, and movies far more than when I worked. It's all possible if you follow the rule:

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**Spend on yourself, not on your assets**

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In 1982–83 higher-income Americans spent a median \$2,552 per month after taxes, savings, and retirement contributions,